

COUNT TO 15, THEN ANSWER ANY PRODUCT QUESTION

Design an Alarm Clock for People Who Hit Snooze

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1 Buy time, then count to 15

Tell the interviewer you're taking a moment, then breathe and count to 15 in your head. Do it even if you already know how you'd start. Use the count to decide what you'd ask first.

EXAMPLE

"Give me a few seconds to think this through."

When you hit 15, don't start designing. Ask your questions.

2 Ask clarifying questions

For a design question, ask three to five. Pick the ones that change your answer the most. "People who hit snooze" could mean students, shift workers, or parents. "Alarm clock" could mean a phone app or a clock on the nightstand.

EXAMPLE

"Is this a phone app or a physical clock? Who's it for, students, people with early jobs, or everyone? Is the goal getting up on time or waking up less groggy?"

Repeat their answer back before you move on: "Got it, a physical clock for people with early jobs, and the goal is getting out of bed on the first alarm."

3 Break it apart on paper

Write the question at the top of the page and split it into layers before you pick anything. Go from who, to what bugs them, to ideas. Don't pick a design yet.

EXAMPLE

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Alarm clock for people who hit snooze
├ Users: early-shift workers, students, heavy sleepers
│   └ Why they hit snooze: _____
│       └ Ideas for each reason: _____
│           └ The one you pick: _____
│               └ How you'd measure it: _____
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Fill in the blanks out loud. Turn the page toward the interviewer so they can follow along.

4 Work it top down

Go one layer at a time and say why at every step. Name the user, the pain point, three ideas, then pick one.

EXAMPLE

1. Start with early-shift workers. Being late costs them money, so they want this most.
User: early-shift workers
2. Say the reason they snooze is the button is in reach, so they hit it before they're awake.
Pain point: snoozing half asleep
3. Three ideas: a clock you walk across the room to turn off, a light that brightens before the alarm, and an alarm that stops only when you stand on a mat.
Ideas: walk-to-off, sunrise light, floor mat
4. Pick the floor mat. Standing up is the hard part, and the mat makes you do it.
Pick: alarm that stops when you stand on the mat
5. Say how you'd measure it. If it works, people get up on the first alarm.
Metric: share of mornings up on the first alarm

If they push back on your user or pain point, take theirs and keep going.

5 Check it with the interviewer

You can't run user research in the room, so the interviewer is your user. Say your pick and ask if it's the direction they want. They'll agree, push on a corner case, or point you somewhere else. Answer the corner case, then give a rough cost and time to build.

EXAMPLE

You: "I'd build an alarm that only turns off when you stand on a mat next to the bed. Does that direction work?"

Interviewer: "What happens if the power goes out?"

You: "It runs on a backup battery, so the alarm still goes off. Another corner case: two people share the bed and only one gets up early, so the mat goes on that person's side. It's a clock, a mat and a battery, so a first version could be ready in about 3 months."

Interviewer: "Makes sense."

If they point you somewhere else, don't defend your first pick. Go back to your tree, take the next idea, and run it through the same checks.

Practice on this one

Set a 10-minute timer, have a friend play the interviewer, and record it. Run all five steps out loud, count included. Play it back and flag any idea you picked without saying why.

- ☐ Design an elevator for blind people.

Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I say "give me a few seconds" and count to 15?
- ☐ Did I ask three to five clarifying questions and repeat the goal back?
- ☐ Did I sketch users, pain points and ideas on paper before picking?
- ☐ Did I pick one idea and say why?
- ☐ Did I handle the interviewer's corner case and give a rough cost and time?
- ☐ Did I say how I'd measure it?